



Slovenian / University

Slovenian University Strategic Plan 2026-2031

A five-year commitment to legibility,
assurance, and delivery



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Chancellor's message

As Chancellor, I am pleased to commend this Strategic Plan to the University community. Governing Council has followed the development of this plan closely, and has taken particular interest in its commitment to building an assurance architecture proportionate to an institution of this scale and ambition — a commitment Council will hold the Executive to across the full five years of the plan, not only at its close. I commend the plan, and the discipline it asks of the institution that adopts it, to every member of our community.

The five years ahead will test the University's capacity to deliver at the scale this plan describes, and Council's own oversight will draw increasingly on the assurance information the plan's first pillar is designed to produce. That is a novel arrangement for a governing body accustomed to receiving assurance in retrospect, and Council has approved it in that knowledge, not in spite of it.

Chancellor

A message from the Vice-Chancellor

A plan is a promise a university makes to itself before it makes it to anyone else, and the surest way to break that promise is never to notice the moment it starts slipping. Over the five years to 2031, Slop University will hold itself to a standard beyond the customary one: not only will this plan set out what the University intends to become, but it will carry, built into its own architecture, the means of knowing continuously whether that becoming is actually under way.



This is a plan for the national interest, for research excellence carried at scale, and for an education equal to the decade ahead — and it is also, deliberately, a plan about how a university comes to trust its own account of itself. The University's places, from its laboratories to its lecture theatres to the quieter corners where good ideas first get argued over coffee, remain where the work of the plan actually happens; nothing in what follows changes that. What changes is the confidence with which the University can say, at any point across the five years, how far along it is.

We have not always got this right. Earlier plans asked the community to trust that delivery was occurring; this one asks the University to be able to show it, continuously, to itself first and to everyone else after. That is a harder discipline than writing good pillars, and we do not pretend it will be comfortable throughout. It is, we believe, the discipline this decade requires.

Vice-Chancellor and President

Executive summary

This plan is organised around four pillars: Institutional Assurance and Foresight, Research Excellence and Discovery, Education for an Uncertain Decade, and Place, Partnership, and Belonging. Together they carry the University's commitments for the five years to 2031, and together they are held to a single further condition — that progress against each is visible, in close to real time, to the University itself.



Institutional Assurance and Foresight

The architecture that tracks whether every commitment in this plan, including its own, is being kept.



Research Excellence and Discovery

Deepening the University's research base across foundational and applied work alike.



Education for an Uncertain Decade

Preparing graduates for work that does not yet fully exist.



Place, Partnership, and Belonging

Strengthening the University's standing in its region and its community.

Institutional Assurance and Foresight is the newest of the four pillars and, in a specific sense, the one the other three now answer to: it establishes the systems by which the University tracks whether its own strategic commitments are being met, and directs resourcing toward whichever commitment most needs it in a given quarter. Research Excellence and Discovery, Education for an Uncertain Decade, and Place, Partnership, and Belonging each carry forward long-standing University priorities — deepening the research base, reshaping education for a decade of rapid change, and strengthening the University's place in its community and its region — and each now reports, as a matter of course, into the assurance architecture the first pillar provides.

This is a deliberate redesign of how the plan works, not just what it contains. Earlier plans set commitments and reviewed them annually; this plan treats the space between reviews as itself something to be managed, monitored, and where necessary, corrected. The plan is structured to be read in either direction: as a statement of four priorities the University is choosing to pursue, or as a single system of delivery in which those priorities are the moving parts. Implementation phases beginning in 2026 sequence delivery across the plan period; the governance arrangements set out later in this document describe how the Council and the Executive will draw on the assurance architecture in their own oversight function.

The ambitions in the pages that follow are, in the ordinary sense, ambitious: a stronger research base, a more relevant education, a more connected regional presence. What is different about this plan is not the size of those ambitions but the University's confidence that it will be able to say, credibly and without waiting for the five-year mark, how close it has come.

Our values

Legibility — we hold that a university should be able to explain, at any moment, what it is doing and how it knows.

Excellence — we hold ourselves to the standards expected of a research university of international standing, in what we discover and how we teach it.

Belonging — we build a University that feels, to everyone who studies or works here, like a place they helped make.

Stewardship — we treat the resources entrusted to us — public, philanthropic, and human — as something we account for, not simply spend.

Where we stand

The environment in which this plan is set is one of rising expectation and thinning patience. Governments, funders, and the communities a university serves increasingly ask not only what a university intends to do but how it will know, and how soon, whether the intention has become the outcome. Reporting cycles that once ran annually now run to the funding round, the parliamentary question, the audit cycle, and, increasingly, to the tempo of a public conversation that does not wait for a university's usual rhythms.



At the same time, the tools available to a university for knowing itself have changed faster than the governance arrangements built to use them. Dashboards, automated indicators, and AI-assisted monitoring systems are now technically straightforward to build across a large, decentralised institution; the harder question, and the one this plan answers, is how such systems are governed once they exist — who they report to, what happens when they disagree with a unit's own account of its progress, and how their outputs are weighed against the judgement of the people doing the work. A university that adopts these tools without answering that question risks a plan that is monitored everywhere and understood nowhere.

Slop University's research base continues to grow in scale and in the range of problems it takes on, from foundational questions to capability of national significance to work that only becomes legible as a discipline years after it starts. Education is changing under comparable pressure: students arrive with different expectations of pace, of relevance, and of what a qualification is meant to certify, and the University's programs must keep pace without losing the depth that makes a Slop University education worth having. And the University's place — in its region, in the national research system, and in the communities that host its campuses and partnerships — remains the setting in which all of this work actually happens, whatever a dashboard says about it.

Comparable institutions, in Australia and abroad, are experimenting with versions of this same problem, from real-time compliance dashboards in the public sector to automated assurance tooling in research-intensive industries. The lesson so far is not that the technology is difficult — it is that the technology outpaces the governance built to hold it accountable, producing systems that generate confident numbers nobody has actually tested against the judgement of the people the numbers

describe. Slop University does not intend to repeat that mistake at its own scale, and the governance arrangements later in this plan are written with it specifically in mind.

Set against this environment, the case for this plan’s central innovation is straightforward to state, even if it will not be straightforward to build: a university this large, working across this many domains, cannot rely on annual retrospection to know whether it is on track. It needs an assurance capability proportionate to its own complexity — one that does not replace the judgement of researchers, educators, and professional staff, but gives the institution, and the people who lead it, a continuously current account of where the plan stands. Building that capability, and building it in a way that strengthens rather than substitutes for the University’s other work, is what the pillars that follow set out to do.

What we will become

By 2031, Slop University will be a university that knows itself in close to real time.

This is not a claim about technology for its own sake. It is a claim about trust: that a university confident enough to make its own progress visible, continuously and to itself first, is a university better placed to correct course early, to resource what is working, and to say to government, to partners, and to its own community — with evidence rather than assurance alone — that its commitments are being kept. The University’s researchers will keep asking the questions only a research-intensive institution can ask; its educators will keep preparing graduates for work that does not yet fully exist; its campuses and partnerships will keep anchoring it in place. What will be different, by 2031, is that none of this will need to wait until the end of the plan period to be known — by the University, or by anyone it answers to.

From	To
Progress reported once a year	Progress visible at every point in the cycle
Assurance treated as overhead on delivery	Assurance treated as a pillar of delivery
Each pillar accounting for itself	A single delivery record the whole University shares
Confidence in delivery assumed	Confidence in delivery scored, continuously
Risk noticed after a review finds it	Risk flagged before the review is due

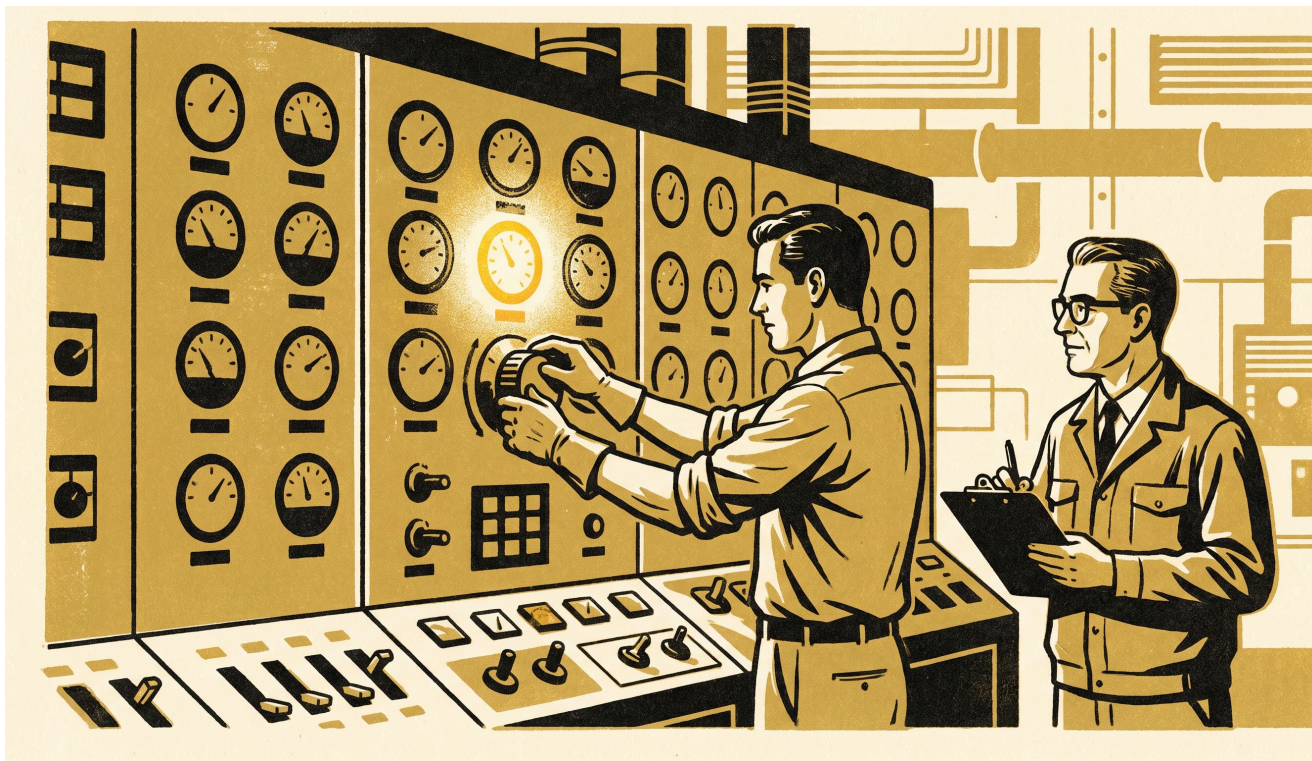
Our agenda

Institutional Assurance and Foresight

Why this matters

The University has, in effect, run four plans at once for as long as it has had four kinds of unit reporting on their own progress in their own terms and on their own schedule. That approach served the institution reasonably well when its scale was smaller and its obligations to funders and government were lighter; it no longer does. Institutional Assurance and Foresight exists to give the University a single, continuously current account of how its strategic commitments — across every pillar, including this one — are actually tracking, and to direct attention and resourcing toward whichever commitment needs it most in a given quarter, rather than waiting for the commitment to fail publicly first. That redirection is itself now a standing feature of how the University is run, not a one-off correction — a scale of change that, we recognise, asks more of every pillar lead than any previous planning cycle has.

External advice on how such a system should be built, and how it should be received by the people it measures, is drawn from the University's own research capability: Dr Anneke Tolan, Senior Research Fellow in the School of Emergent Priorities, whose fieldwork traces how planning is actually practised inside institutions, will advise the program on how delivery-confidence scoring lands with the units it covers, and on where the architecture's design should bend to fit the practice rather than the reverse.



What we'll do

1. Establish an AI-governance early-warning system spanning every pillar and budget line of this plan, reporting a live delivery-confidence score to the Council and the Executive.
2. Bring each pillar's reporting into a single assurance architecture, replacing the separate reporting rhythms each pillar has historically kept.
3. Direct a standing share of pillar funding, reallocated quarterly, toward whichever pillar's delivery-confidence score is lowest in that quarter — including, where the data supports it, this pillar's own build-out.

How we'll know

- By 2028, 100% of pillar-level budget lines across the plan will be visible to the early-warning system in real time, with no exception sustained for more than a single reporting cycle.
- By 2029, the median time between a delivery risk emerging and its appearing on the Council's assurance dashboard will fall under one reporting cycle.
- By 2031, at least one full cycle of quarterly reallocation will have been completed without a pillar's delivery-confidence score requiring escalation to external review.

Research Excellence and Discovery

Why this matters

A research university earns its standing through the work its researchers do, not through the plan that describes it; this pillar exists to keep that work growing in scale, in ambition, and in the range of problems it takes on, while giving the University — for the first time on a continuous basis — a current account of how its research investment is actually tracking against what was promised. It also gives the University's research leadership, for the first time, a shared account of how investment decisions across schools and institutes are actually landing, rather than a picture assembled only at each grant round or annual report.

What we'll do

1. Diversify the University's research income base across competitive grant funding, philanthropic support, and industry and government collaboration.
2. Expand doctoral training capacity and strengthen the candidate experience across every school.
3. Renew major research infrastructure and align priority investment with capability of recognised national significance.

How we'll know

- External research income growing from a mixed funding base to reach \$450M–\$600M annually by 2031.
- HDR completions reaching 2,800–3,400 over the plan period.
- 90% of major infrastructure investment decisions visible to the assurance architecture within one reporting cycle of approval.

Education for an Uncertain Decade

Why this matters

Graduates who leave Slop University in 2031 will enter a labour market substantially reshaped from the one their degree was designed against; this pillar exists to keep the curriculum, and the judgement behind it, moving at the same pace as the world it prepares people for. It is also the pillar most exposed to the pace of external change, since the tools and expectations shaping graduate work in 2031 are, in large part, not yet invented.

What we'll do

1. Renew core curricula across every degree to build durable capability rather than tool-specific skill.
2. Expand work-integrated learning so that every undergraduate program carries a substantial applied component by 2029.
3. Build AI-fluency and assurance literacy into every program, so graduates understand not only how these systems work but how they should be governed.

How we'll know

- 100% of undergraduate programs carrying a renewed core curriculum by 2029.
- Work-integrated learning participation reaching 80% of undergraduate completions by 2031.
- Graduate outcomes surveys showing sustained improvement in reported work-readiness across three consecutive cohorts.

Place, Partnership, and Belonging

Why this matters

A university's standing in its region and its community is not a pillar that can be delivered from a dashboard; it is built through the ordinary, cumulative work of partnership, presence, and welcome, and this pillar exists to keep that work central to the plan even as the other three pillars grow more instrumented around it. Its success is measured less by a single indicator than by whether the people closest to the University — students, staff, and neighbouring communities — recognise the change described here in their own experience of the place.



What we'll do

1. Deepen partnerships with regional government, industry, and community organisations across the University's campuses.
2. Extend student and staff belonging programs, with particular attention to those newest to the University.
3. Improve the accessibility and openness of University spaces, on campus and online, for the communities the University serves.

How we'll know

- Regional and community partnerships reaching 90–130 active arrangements over the plan period.
- Staff and student belonging survey scores improving in each year of the plan.
- Public and community use of University spaces and programs increasing year on year.

How we will deliver this plan

Delivery runs across four contiguous phases spanning the plan period.

Establish, 2026. The assurance architecture is specified and the reporting rhythms of the other three pillars are mapped against it; early governance arrangements are put in place ahead of full deployment. Early pillar leads are appointed and provided with baseline data against which subsequent quarters will be measured.

Build, 2027–28. The early-warning system is built out across every pillar and budget line, and the University’s first full cycle of quarterly reallocation is tested under governance oversight before it carries live funding decisions. Early results from the reallocation trial are reported to Council in full, including cases where the recommended reallocation was overridden by the Executive.

Embed, 2029–30. Delivery-confidence scoring becomes the University’s standard account of progress against this plan, replacing the annual reporting rhythms it succeeds; each pillar’s initiatives are recalibrated against what the assurance architecture has by then made visible. By this stage, unit-level reporting that duplicates the assurance architecture’s own functions is retired rather than run in parallel.

Renew, 2031. The plan closes with a full assessment of what the assurance architecture has shown about the University’s own capacity for delivery, feeding directly into the plan that follows. That assessment, and the plan it produces, will themselves be prepared under the same assurance discipline they describe.

Accountability and review

The University Council retains ultimate oversight of this plan and receives the assurance architecture’s delivery-confidence reporting each quarter, alongside the narrative account each pillar lead provides in the ordinary course. The Executive is accountable for delivery against every initiative in this document and for the quarterly reallocation decisions the assurance architecture recommends, which remain decisions for the Executive to make rather than actions the system takes on its own authority.

The question of whether the assurance architecture itself remains proportionate to what it oversees is not one the architecture can answer about itself. That review sits with the School of Continuous Improvement’s Evaluation of Evaluation program, convened by Dr Dagny Okafor, which will periodically assess whether the assurance system’s own scope, cost, and authority remain in proportion to the delivery risk it was built to manage, and report that assessment to the Council independently of the pillar it reviews.

The decade ahead

The five years to 2031 will ask more of Slop University than any single plan period has asked before — not because the ambitions in this document are larger than earlier ones, though in places they are, but because the University is asking itself to hold those ambitions to a higher standard of proof as it goes. A university that can show its work, continuously and honestly, is a university better placed to earn the trust the decade ahead will demand of it. This is the university Slop University intends to become, and the account of how it is becoming that university will, for the first time, be available before the five years are up.



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